

Surviving the Bloody Hundredth: The Service of Murray Lirette

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In December 1941, Louisiana-native Murray Lirette was a freshman at Louisiana State University (LSU), where he was an active member of the ROTC and an accomplished athlete in several sports. However, the successes in these activities came at the expense of Lirette's academics. As he anticipated being drafted, and given his interest in aviation, Lirette decided to enlist in the Army Air Forces in October 1942. "You might say the war saved me from further embarrassment at LSU," remarked Lirette.

After several months of cadet training in Santa Ana, California, Lirette and many other cadets were assembled in an auditorium and informed they were classified as bombardiers. Lirette continued with bombardier training and was subsequently assigned to a B-17 crew in Pyote, Texas in October 1943. Though shortly thereafter, his pilot and co-pilot were transferred to a B-29 training group, leaving Lirette without a crew. Lirette worked as an instructor on base until one day he was called into the Chief's office and told the Jack Hunter crew had lost its bombardier, and was about to depart for England. Lirette volunteered for this assignment and traveled to Kearney, Nebraska to meet the crew.

After arriving in England, the Hunter crew was assigned to the 100th Bomb Group on Lirette's birthday, April 6, 1944, and by May 8th, they had completed ten missions, including two to Berlin. Lirette wore a flak suit during missions, and always hooked his parachute on the right side of the parachute harness so that it hung down the right side of his body, and allowed the flak suit to fit snugly. Lirette hoped he would be able to swing the parachute over and latch the second hook quickly if something happened.

On May 11, 1944, the 100th flew a mission to Liege, Belgium targeting a marshalling yard. While approaching the target, Lirette recalled there were four 88mm anti-aircraft guns firing at the formation of bombers, and the flak bursts continued to get closer and closer as they proceeded ahead. During the bomb run, Lirette opened the bomb bay doors, and "waited anxiously" for the lead plane to drop his bombs. After what "seemed like hours", Lirette saw the first bombs drop and he pushed the bomb release switch. The next four flak bursts were very close and Lirette noted he was "paying more attention to the bursts than to the bomb release." Shortly after calling out "bombs away" over the intercom, their B-17 was hit by flak. Lirette heard a "loud bang", and their B-17 lurched to the right and the wing dipped. Lirette knew the plane was going down and realized they had to bail out. However, Lirette was thrown against the side of the plane and could not move toward the escape hatch. The thought of his parents went through Lirette's mind as he knew they would be saddened to learn of his death. Just then there was a second muffled explosion. Lirette believes the first explosion could have hit a wing

tank, and fuel may have seeped into the fuselage causing the second explosion. In an instant, everything went red and Lirette temporarily lost consciousness. Lirette awoke to find himself free falling at approximately 15,000 feet. Instinctively, he pulled the rip cord, even though only one side of the parachute was hooked to his harness. After the parachute deployed, Lirette tried to hook up the other side of the parachute; however, in doing so the "chute fluttered like it was going to close." Lirette "decided to leave well enough alone and did not try again." As his parachute was only hooked on one side, it caused Lirette to descend at an angle and he landed in a tree, roughly two miles away from where fellow crew members Dick Heh and Herbert South landed.

After getting down from the tree, Lirette discovered he had been wounded in his left buttock, left knee and ankle, and could feel blood pooling in his left shoe. Lirette used the morphine from his medical kit to kill the pain and briefly laid down on the ground. Shortly thereafter, a middle-aged man in hiking clothes approached. Lirette recalled the man spoke very good English, and after looking over his wounds, the man said if Lirette had not been hurt he would take him along, which he inferred to mean an underground escape network. The man told Lirette to remain there and others would soon come to take care of him. After about 10 minutes, several Belgian civilians showed up, and a male and female doctor also arrived. The doctors applied medication and wrapped gauze around his leg. A couple of the civilians cut some nearby trees to make a stretcher, and under the supervision of two German soldiers that arrived, Lirette was loaded into a waiting ambulance.

Lirette was taken to a local hospital's operating room and was administered chloroform prior to the doctor operating. Lirette awoke to find he was alone in a small room in the hospital. While recovering, Dick Heh was brought in to identify Lirette, and told Lirette that he and Herbert South were the only other survivors from their crew. Lirette recalled Heh was in bad shape and had torn clothes with blood splatters and burns. Lirette was later moved to a POW hospital in Brussels where he received additional treatment for his wounds. Following the D-Day landings, Lirette was told he would be moved elsewhere to make room for incoming wounded German soldiers. Lirette and other POWs were first transported via train cars to a German compound in Stuttgart for interrogation, and Lirette was subsequently sent to Stalag Luft III. Lirette recalled "as we walked through the gate, the other prisoners lined the roadway looking for their other crew members. Dick Heh was there and soon grabbed my hand and shook it."

In late 1944, as the Russian offensive advanced, food rations within the camp began to diminish. That winter was "so cold", and "we went to bed hungry almost every night," noted Lirette. The POWs at Stalag Luft III were able to monitor the Allied advance by way of a radio they kept hidden, and on the morning of January 27, 1944, the Germans informed the POWs

that Stalag Luft III would be evacuated and everyone would be marched westward as the Russians were approaching. Late that evening, the evacuation began, and Lirette and his fellow POWs in the West compound of the camp were moved out at 12:30 a.m. The grueling 20 mile march, through freezing winds and snow, had begun, and each POW brought along whatever he was able to carry, including one Red Cross food parcel. Lirette wore all the clothes he had and wrapped himself up in a blanket but was still freezing. The German guards kept everyone moving and "passed the word around that anyone who tried to escape or lays down to sleep would probably freeze to death." During the first portion of this trek, the group marched until about 9:00 a.m. the next day, and then briefly stopped at a crossroads where there was a building with toilets and drinking water. Around 6:00 p.m, word was passed down that anyone who could no longer keep up the pace should fall out to the side of the road. At that time, Lirette's wounds had still not fully healed and his left ankle and knee became swollen and very painful, therefore he decided to move off to the side with seven other POWs. Lirette's group proceeded ahead at a slower pace and were escorted by one elderly guard. The group's only shelter that night was a nearby unheated pub, where they slept on the floor; though Lirette noted "this was still better than staying outside in the freezing weather."

After marching 10 miles the next day, the guard stopped the group at a house along the side of the road, which turned out to belong to the local burgermeister (mayor). The burgermeister greeted the group and gave each POW 4-5 apples from his orchard. Soon after, two horse-drawn sleds arrived and the POWs loaded aboard and continued toward their destination, which to the POWs remained unknown. Lirette's group traveled at a much faster rate in the sleds, and at one point passed the columns of marching POWs. That afternoon they arrived in Muskau, about 20 miles east of Spremberg, Germany, and spent the night on the upper floors of a brick factory, which was the first time they were able to get warm since the march began.

The next day, the POWs were marched to Spremberg and were loaded into railway cars which had been used for livestock. "Complaints were useless, and travel by rail in the smelly cars was at little better than walking," recalled Lirette. After three days of rail travel, the POWs arrived on the outskirts of Nuremberg and were taken to an overcrowded POW encampment. The cold weather took its toll on Lirette, who developed a severe sinus infection during his first days at the camp. As the Germans could offer no medical assistance at the camp, Lirette was taken to a nearby POW hospital and was attended to by German orderlies. As the Germans prepared to evacuate the area, Lirette was deemed to be unable to travel, given his condition, and was left in the hospital with 10 other American and British POWs. Before departing, the German doctor gave Lirette two white pills and instructed him to take one each night; which gradually helped.

Lirette's final days as a POW were spent in the underground shelter of the hospital to avoid any explosions from artillery shells in the area. Liberation came on April 17, when two American GIs in a jeep arrived at the hospital. They handed two bottles of wine to the POWs and advised, "the tanks will be here soon." A few hours later, tanks from General Patton's 3rd Army arrived, and the POWs were helped into Army trucks and taken to France. Reflecting on that day, Lirette said "I was so elated and happy... and it's hard to express my feelings of that day. There were times during my captivity where I didn't know if I would make it."

Upon arrival in France, Lirette was deloused, given food and clothes, and then taken on a DC-3 to Scotland. After three weeks of recuperation at a hospital in Scotland, Lirette was sent to England, where he boarded an LST ship bound for Newport News, Virginia. When Lirette finally arrived home in Houma, Louisiana, his parents were "so happy," as they had only received a couple of the letters he sent while in Stalag Luft III.

Lirette was discharged in November 1945, and after receiving a stern directive from his father about attending school, Lirette signed up for classes at LSU and majored in electrical engineering. Lirette remains thankful for his father's direction, and for the discipline his parents instilled. For more than 30 years, Lirette worked in the aircraft development sector, and had the unique opportunity to work with NASA on projects related to the space program. In 2019, Lirette was a recipient of the "Every Moment Counts" Award, presented by a local civic organization for seniors who remain active in the community. Reflecting on his World War II service, Lirette stated *"I am very proud to be a part of the 100th Bomb Group. We lost a lot of men, but we did a lot of good and we contributed to the bombing effort against the Germans."*